had given audiences to only three other national leaders before he met Modi—Japan's Shigeru Ishiba, Israel's Benjamin Netanyahu and Jordan's King Abdullah II. So, it signalled the priority that Trump accorded to his relations with Modi and India. Yet it was a high-risk gambit for Modi, given Trump's reputation of being mercurial and brutally frank, let alone his penchant for making atrocious demands. But the Indian team had prepared well, utilising the two-month transition period between the Biden and Trump administrations to lay the groundwork for a hopefully fruitful partnership.

A week before Biden passed the baton to Trump, his administration lifted the sanctions on three Indian nuclear establishments—the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre, the Indira Gandhi Centre for Atomic Research and Indian Rare Earths—that had been imposed after the 1998 nuclear tests. This freeing up of restrictions would be vital to rekindle the civilian nuclear cooperation between the two countries that had lain dormant after the signing of the 2008 Indo-US nuclear deal. In return, in the Union budget, India agreed to amend its Atomic Energy Act and the Nuclear Damage Act to relax the stringent liability conditions to enable greater private participation in constructing and running civilian nuclear plants. This would become one of the key elements in the deal struck at the Modi-Trump summit for collaboration in securing critical mineral and clean energy supply chains, apart from India importing US nuclear power reactors.

Meanwhile, Jaishankar was deputed to represent India at Trump's inaugural in Capitol Hill on January 20 and his front row seating along with two foreign ministers of the Quad Group of nations that consists of India, Japan, Australia and the US signalled the new administration's intent to strengthen the Quad, which Trump had pushed for during his first term. This was reiterated by US



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DEFENCE

STEALTHY ARROWHEADS

The US offer to co-produce Stryker combat vehicles and Javelin anti-tank missiles reinforces defence ties. But the sudden arrival of F-35 fighters in the mix has everyone talking

By **PRADIP R. SAGAR**

On February 13, US President Donald Trump, in his renewed tenure in the Oval Office, made a surprising move. At his meeting with PM Narendra Modi, Trump offered India the F-35 stealth fighter, a jet that has so far been restricted to NATO allies, Israel and Japan. "We'll be increasing military sales to India by many billions of dollars.... We're paving the way to provide India with the F-35 stealth fighters," he announced. The supersonic F-35 Lightning II is one of the world's most advanced, multi-role fighter jets, known for its stealth technology and networked warfare capabilities.

More substantively, the US has also offered co-production of its Stryker infantry combat vehicle and Javelin anti-tank guided missile systems. The US has been pitching Stryker to India for over two decades, but things gathered speed after Washington offered its co-production in India a couple of years ago. On January 10, the proposal to establish manufacturing facilities for the Stryker in India were approved by the US government. India plans to have 530 Strykers to equip 10 mechanised infantry battalions to be deployed along the high-altitude LAC. A few units will come off the shelf from the US, while the remainder are expected to be jointly produced here by US firm General Dynamics and an Indian firm. The Javelin anti-tank guided missile system will similarly be jointly produced in India by manufacturers Lockheed Martin and Raytheon, and an Indian firm. India is also expected to order six Boeing